

FOR NEWLY ADOPTED DOGS

The 3-3-3 Decompression Tracker

3 Days · 3 Weeks · 3 Months

A gentle, structured guide to help your rescue or shelter dog
settle in — one step at a time.

FORM & FERN

First 72 Hours: Calm-Home Plan

A simple plan for the first three days — focus on calm, not commands.

- ☐ Picked one quiet, low-traffic room as their home base
- ☐ Set up food, water, and a bed in that same spot each time
- ☐ Kept the leash on for every outdoor bathroom break, even in a fenced yard
- ☐ Blocked off exits and hiding spots you don't want them to access
- ☐ Put away other pets' toys/bowls until everyone has settled in
- ☐ Planned no visitors, parties, or outings for the first 72 hours
- ☐ Kept the household calm: lower voices, fewer sudden movements
- ☐ Let them approach you first — no forced petting or eye contact
- ☐ Confirmed who is "on duty" for the first 72 hours if multiple people live here

Safe Space Setup

Give them one place in the home that always feels safe and predictable.

- ☐ Chose a quiet spot away from doors, windows, and foot traffic
- ☐ Set up a crate, bed, or mat with a blanket that has a familiar scent
- ☐ Made sure the space has an exit they can see and reach — never a dead end
- ☐ Kept the space consistent — same spot, same bedding, every day
- ☐ Told household members this spot is off-limits when they're using it
- ☐ Added a chew toy or enrichment item they can self-soothe with
- ☐ Checked the spot is a comfortable temperature (not near vents/drafts)
- ☐ Introduced kids and guests to the "leave them alone here" rule
- ☐ Noted whether they're using the space on their own by day 3

Daily Routine Builder

Predictability helps a nervous dog relax faster. Build the same simple loop each day.

- ☐ Set a consistent wake-up time (within about 30 minutes daily)
- ☐ Set 2–3 consistent feeding times at the same spot each day
- ☐ Scheduled a short morning walk or yard time, same time each day
- ☐ Set aside 5–10 minutes of quiet, low-key attention time
- ☐ Scheduled a consistent "settle" period (crate, mat, or safe space)
- ☐ Set a consistent bedtime and wind-down routine
- ☐ Picked one consistent word for mealtime and one for walk time
- ☐ Wrote the routine somewhere visible for everyone in the house
- ☐ Kept the routine as similar as possible on weekends too

Food, Water & Sleep Watch List

Simple things to notice each day — not a diagnosis, just useful patterns to track.

- ☐ Noted whether they ate a full, partial, or no meal today
- ☐ Noted whether they drank water normally, more than usual, or barely at all
- ☐ Noted roughly how many hours they slept vs. stayed alert and watchful
- ☐ Noted any change in bathroom habits worth mentioning at their vet visit
- ☐ Noted whether meals were eaten calmly or anxiously/quickly
- ☐ Noted any day where sleep or appetite was notably different from the day before
- ☐ Circled or starred any pattern that repeated 3+ days in a row
- ☐ Wrote down the date they started eating full meals consistently
- ☐ Flagged anything unusual to bring up at their first vet visit

Trigger & Comfort Log

Notice what unsettles them and what helps — this becomes your dog's personal playbook.

- ☐ Noted specific sounds that caused a startle or freeze response
- ☐ Noted specific situations (guests, cars, other dogs) that raised alertness
- ☐ Noted the earliest signs of stress you saw (yawning, lip licking, stiffening)
- ☐ Noted what helped them settle back down each time
- ☐ Noted their favorite calming spot, toy, or activity so far
- ☐ Noted which family member or approach they responded to most calmly
- ☐ Noted any trigger that seemed to fade with repeated calm exposure
- ☐ Wrote down one thing to avoid repeating that clearly overwhelmed them
- ☐ Starred any trigger worth discussing with a certified trainer

First 3 Days: A Reflection

A short space to process this huge transition — for the dog, and for you.

- ☐ What surprised you most about their personality so far?
- ☐ What was harder than you expected these first few days?
- ☐ What went better than you expected?
- ☐ What's one small win worth celebrating from today?
- ☐ What's one thing you'd do differently if you were starting over?
- ☐ How are you feeling about this transition, honestly?
- ☐ What questions are you still sitting with after day 3?
- ☐ What's one thing you're already grateful for about this dog?
- ☐ What's one thing you want to remember about this exact moment?

Weeks 1–3: Routine Tracker

Now that the dust has settled, start layering in gentle structure.

- ☐ Feeding and bathroom breaks are becoming predictable and consistent
- ☐ Introduced a consistent bedtime and wake-up routine
- ☐ Started short, positive-only training sessions (5–10 minutes)
- ☐ Practiced their name and one basic cue in a quiet space
- ☐ Slowly introduced one new person or place, one at a time
- ☐ Watched body language during new experiences (tail, ears, posture)
- ☐ Began identifying their specific comfort signals vs. stress signals
- ☐ Explored the house room-by-room at their own pace
- ☐ Started building a positive association with the crate or resting spot

Months 1–3: Progress Tracker

Trust deepens here. This is where their real personality starts to show.

- ☐ Personality is coming through — noted what makes them, them
- ☐ Responding to their name and basic cues consistently
- ☐ Has one or more clear favorite people, places, or toys
- ☐ Comfortable being left alone for short periods
- ☐ Scheduled or completed a wellness check-up appointment
- ☐ Socialization is progressing at their own pace, not on a deadline
- ☐ Identified their long-term triggers and a plan to manage them
- ☐ Considered whether a certified trainer's support would help
- ☐ Gave yourself credit for the patience this journey has taken

Questions For Your Vet or Trainer

Bring this list to your first appointment — you don't have to remember everything.

- ☐ Is their weight, coat, and energy level within a healthy range?
- ☐ What vaccinations or preventive care are due, and when?
- ☐ Is their current food appropriate, or should we discuss alternatives?
- ☐ What's a realistic timeline for house-training or routine adjustment?
- ☐ Which logged behaviors are typical adjustment vs. worth watching?
- ☐ Would a certified trainer help with a specific behavior I've noted?
- ☐ What's the best way to introduce them to other pets or people safely?
- ☐ Are there local classes, trainers, or behaviorists you'd recommend?
- ☐ What symptoms should prompt an immediate call, not a wait-and-see?

New Home Emergency Information

Fill this out once and keep it somewhere everyone in the household can find it.

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- ☐ Vet clinic name, phone number, and address
 - ☐ Nearest 24-hour emergency animal hospital and phone number
 - ☐ Microchip number and registry, if known
 - ☐ Adoption or rescue organization contact, in case of questions
 - ☐ Current medications, supplements, or known allergies
 - ☐ Emergency contact person if you're unreachable
 - ☐ Pet insurance provider and policy number, if applicable
 - ☐ Where their leash, carrier, and go-bag are kept
 - ☐ A recent photo saved somewhere easy to find, in case they get lost

Family Consistency Sheet

Everyone in the house using the same rules and words helps them settle in faster.

- ☐ Agreed on the same word for mealtime across all household members
- ☐ Agreed on the same word for walks and potty breaks
- ☐ Agreed on whether furniture and bed access is allowed, and where
- ☐ Agreed on who feeds, walks, and lets them out, and when
- ☐ Agreed on how guests should (and shouldn't) greet them at first
- ☐ Agreed on what to do if they seem overwhelmed at a family gathering
- ☐ Posted the routine somewhere every household member can see it
- ☐ Talked with kids about giving space and reading calm body language
- ☐ Checked in as a household after week 1 on what's working and what isn't

Progress Without Deadlines

The 3-3-3 rule is a guide, not a deadline. Every dog moves at their own pace.

- ☐ Sign of progress: taking treats gently from your hand
- ☐ Sign of progress: choosing to be in the same room as you, unprompted
- ☐ Sign of progress: a relaxed body — soft eyes, loose tail, normal breathing
- ☐ Sign of progress: a full-body shake-off after something stressful (a great sign!)
- ☐ Sign of progress: seeking you out for comfort or attention
- ☐ Sign of progress: playful moments, even short or clumsy ones
- ☐ Reminder: setbacks are normal and don't erase progress already made
- ☐ Reminder: "on their own timeline" is a real strategy, not a lack of one
- ☐ Gave yourself credit for the patience this journey has taken